Predicting the future

SEE ALSO

❮ **54–55** Build-your-own computers
❮ **56–57** Wearable computers
❮ **88–89** Databases
The Internet of Things **226–227** ❯
Virtual reality **228–229** ❯
Cryptocurrencies **230–231** ❯

Technology is always changing. People have been trying to imagine the future of technology for hundreds of years. Some modern developments seem like they will have an impact on the future, but it is always hard to be certain.

On the horizon

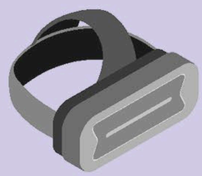
Inventions don't just pop out of nowhere: they're built on mountains of previous discoveries, designs, and failures. Specific predictions may be impossible, but it's broadly possible to see the big picture of where technology is heading, especially over the next few years. Some inventions, such as virtual reality, have been around for a while but have found a new lease of life with modern computing capabilities. Others, such as cryptocurrencies, are relatively new and are harder to be sure about.

IN DEPTH

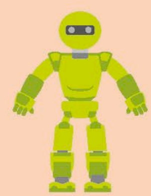
Why predict?

Accurate predictions help industries decide where to focus their research efforts. If people know that nuclear-powered jetpacks are a bad idea, they won't pour time and money into inventing them. Predictions also help countries create new laws to deal with technology. Imagine how chaotic the world would be if traffic laws had never been created, or no one had bothered to standardize currents and voltages. Currently, many countries are struggling to define digital rights.

△ **Augmented reality (AR)**
Whether it's adding quirky filters to social media videos or superimposing information on eyeglasses, AR is making the world more customizable and interactive. Education, games, and even navigation are all changing.



△ **Virtual reality (VR)**
VR headsets are catapulting users into 360-degree virtual worlds. VR simulators have existed for years, and advances in hardware have finally made them more affordable.



△ **Robots**
Autonomous drones for surveillance, military combat, and search and rescue are now a reality. There are even cars that can drive themselves. While useful, it means more jobs are being lost to automation.

△ **Makerspaces**
These are work spaces where people can access high-tech tools such as 3D printers and Arduino boards. The maker mindset focuses on creativity, collaboration, and building things with new technologies.

△ **3D printing**
3D printers are becoming increasingly cheap and accessible. In addition to inspiring new trends, they are important in manufacturing and medicine, and are used to create engine parts, jewellery, and even prosthetic hands.

△ **Big data**
Everything from phones to watches has sensors nowadays. The same goes for industrial devices such as turbines and trains. These sensors create a huge amount of data that can be harvested for all kinds of uses.